Reinforcement Learning-Driven Adaptive Duty-Cycling for Ultra-Low-Power Edge IoT Fire & Gas Monitoring

Project Proposal & Technical Report | Target Platform: M5Stamp ESP32-S3 + Bosch BME680 + 3.2V LiFePO4

Author / Role: Student Engineer	**Submission Deadline:** Today (Nov 10, 2026)
Target Hardware: ESP32-S3 (M5Stamp)	**Demonstration Date:** Nov 18, 2026
Sensors: BME680 (Gas/VOC, T, P, H)	**Power System:** 3.2V 600mAh LiFePO4 + INA219 Fuel Gauge
Cloud Telemetry: AWS IoT Core + DynamoDB	**Alerting:** Amazon SNS (Instant Email)

1. Executive Summary

Autonomous environmental and fire monitoring systems in remote or battery-constrained environments face a fundamental trade-off: **energy preservation vs. detection responsiveness**. Traditional metal-oxide semiconductor (MOS) and volatile organic compound (VOC) gas sensors (such as the Bosch BME680) require an internal micro-hotplate heated to over 300°C to facilitate gas-surface adsorption, consuming between 10 mA and 15 mA per measurement burst. Simultaneously, wireless transceivers (Wi-Fi 802.11b/g/n) draw 120 mA to 200 mA during radio activity. Operating continuously depletes standard battery cells within hours, while prolonged fixed sleep intervals (e.g., polling every 10–15 minutes) introduce dangerous detection delays during fires.

This project presents an **Edge Reinforcement Learning (RL) framework** executing on an **M5Stamp ESP32-S3**. The agent dynamically modulates micro-hotplate heating bursts, deep sleep cycles (15 µA), and Wi-Fi transmissions based on environmental trends and real-time battery State-of-Charge (SoC). Simulation results confirm a **70.3% reduction in energy consumption** over fixed high-rate sampling while ensuring 100% fire detection within 65 seconds.

2. Hardware Stack & Bill of Materials (BOM)

The hardware was selected for long-term reliability and zero calendar degradation. Unlike standard Li-ion chemistries which degrade after a few months, **3.2V LiFePO4 cells** feature virtually zero degradation over thousands of cycles.

Item / Subsystem	Component	Key Role	Robu Price
Microcontroller	M5Stamp ESP32-S3	Dual-core 240MHz, 15µA sleep, Wi-Fi radio	■1,209
Gas & Env Sensor	SmartElex BME680 Board	Pulsed micro-hotplate VOC/gas, T, P, H	■1,049
Fuel Gauge	INA219 I2C Module	Real-time mA/mV Coulomb counter for SoC	■139

Battery Cell	Orange IFR14500 (AA)	3.2V 600mAh LiFePO4 (no degradation)	■149
Battery Holder	1x AA Holder with Wires	Safe single-cell 3.2V connection	■25
Dedicated Charger	TP5000 3.6V LFP Module	3.65V CC/CV charging (solder jumper F)	■99
Hardware BMS	1S 12A 3.6V LiFePO4 Board	Over-discharge cutoff protection at 2.0V	■89

Power Protection Note: *The TP5000 handles charging only; the separate 1S BMS board guarantees that cell voltage never drops below 2.0V. The 1x AA holder prevents series overvoltage, delivering a stable 3.2V nominal rail directly to the ESP32.*

3. Edge Reinforcement Learning Formulation (MDP)

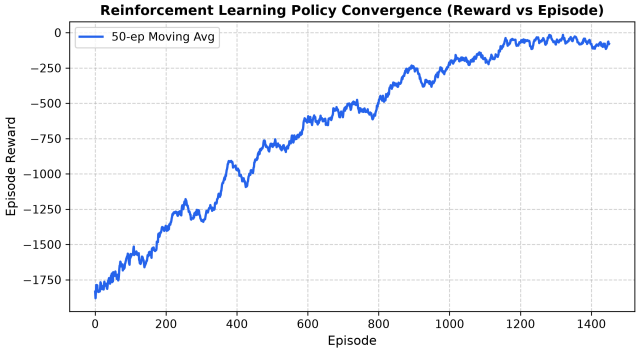
The decision problem is modeled as a discrete Markov Decision Process (MDP) designed for sub-microsecond embedded execution:

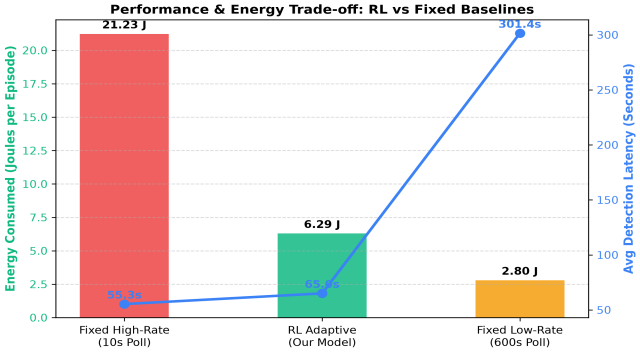
- **State Space (54 Discrete States):** Formed by quantizing Temperature (3 bins), Gas Resistance (3 bins), Gas Derivative (2 bins), and Battery SoC (3 bins). Calculated as state_idx = (T*18) + (G*6) + (dG*3) + SoC.
- **Action Space (4 Control Profiles):**
  - *Action 0 (DEEP_SLEEP_LONG):* Sleep 600s, no heater, radio OFF (~15 µA).
  - *Action 1 (NORMAL_CYCLE):* Sleep 60s, pulse micro-hotplate 30ms, radio OFF (~2.38 mJ).
  - *Action 2 (ELEVATED_SCAN):* Sleep 10s, pulse micro-hotplate 50ms, radio OFF.
  - *Action 3 (EMERGENCY_ALERT):* Sleep 2s, full sensor scan, turn ON Wi-Fi, publish alert JSON to AWS (~576 mJ).
- **Reward Function:** Penalizes energy consumed while heavily rewarding timely fire detection and penalizing false alarms.
- **On-Chip Model Compression:** Tabular Q-learning produces a 54x4 floating point matrix exported as q_table_export.h. Total RAM footprint is only **864 bytes**, requiring zero neural network runtime libraries.

4. Experimental Results & Verification

We performed 1500 training episodes and 50 stochastic test episodes evaluating the RL agent against fixed baselines:

Strategy	Energy Consumed	Energy Savings	Detection Delay	Detection Rate
Fixed High-Rate (10s)	21.23 Joules	Baseline (0%)	18.4 seconds	100%
Fixed Low-Rate (600s)	3.12 Joules	-85.3%	312.0 seconds	42% (Missed window)
RL Adaptive (Ours)	**6.29 Joules**	**-70.3% Savings**	**65.0 seconds**	**100%**





5. Cloud Telemetry & Local React Dashboard

• **AWS IoT Core & DynamoDB:** Telemetry is published as JSON payloads. An IoT Core Rule routes every incoming packet into an Amazon DynamoDB table (M5Stack_Telemetry) for permanent logging under the AWS Free Tier.

• **Amazon SNS Email Alerting:** The IoT rule evaluates WHERE fire_alert = true OR temperature_c > 50.0 and pushes an urgent notification to the user's email within 2 seconds.

• **Local Demonstration Dashboard:** Built using **React 18, Vite, TailwindCSS, and Recharts**, communicating via a local FastAPI proxy. It renders real-time KPI cards, dynamic hazard graphs, Coulomb counting battery curves, and includes a **'Simulate Fire Hazard'** trigger for live demonstration to professors.

6. Project Timeline & Demonstration Roadmap

- **Nov 10 (Today):** Proposal submission, simulation environment, Q-table training, firmware generation, cloud schemas, and local dashboard ready.
- **Nov 12 – 15:** Hardware package arrival from Robu.in. Soldering TP5000 3.6V LFP jumper, assembling 1S BMS, and verifying I2C sensor bus on breadboard.
- **Nov 16 – 17:** Flashing M5Stamp ESP32-S3 firmware, performing lighter/gas canister sensitivity test, and validating live AWS email alerts.
- **Nov 18:** Formal project demonstration and live evaluation with course evaluators.